

Diabetes



- Prevalence of diabetes among adults in urban India is 12%.
- There are 35 million diabetics in India now, slated to reach 75 million in 20 years.

Insulin is Destiny

Indians are said to be predisposed to diabetes. Now medics are saying our diabetes woes start the moment we are born. Low parental birth-weight have been linked with an increased risk of metabolic syndrome in children, according to a study published in the January issue of *Diabetologica*. Scientists are now debating if they should blame genes or the environment.

Obesity



- Over 30% adults in urban India, between 30 and 65, are seriously overweight.
- 50% women in the 35-plus age group are overweight.

It's All in the Waist

Forget the weighing machine, get the tape measurer. Researchers at McMaster University, Canada, have shown that predicting a person's long-term health may be as simple as taking waist by hip measurement. For a 36-inch waist and 40-inch hips, the number would be 0.9. Anything over 0.85 for women and 0.9 for men indicates greater risk of the Big Five.

country—snuffing out lives and taking away productive years. Juxtaposed with stick-thin poverty, malaria and AIDS, chronic diseases account for more than 53 per cent of all deaths and 44 per cent of disability-adjusted life-years. According to the World Health Organisation's (WHO) *Global Burden of Disease Study*, over 30 per cent of adults in urban India, between 30 and 65 years of age, are seriously overweight; death from cardiovascular diseases is nearly 10 million; about eight lakh new cases of cancer are reported every year. Diabetes is projected to stake claim to 57 million people in 2025. And respiratory diseases by air pollution alone take away two billion productive days every year.

Dr Shashank Joshi, endocrinologist with Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, calls it "affluenza". As India gallops into the present, modernising and urbanising at blinding speed, western food habits have taken hold and physical activity has dropped alarmingly. "Televisions, computers and video games fill up our time, while the dramatic increase in cars and two-wheelers on the roads renders it unnecessary to walk to get somewhere," says Joshi. One of the top 10 obese nations in the world, Indians seem even more destined to become heavier and more vulnerable to the lifestyle diseases that are triggered by obesity, inactivity and genes. "This is, unfortunately, the price you pay for progress," says Dr Shaikat M. Sadikot, vice-president of the International Diabetes Federation and consultant endocrinologist with Jaslok Hospital, Mumbai. More people worldwide now die from chronic diseases than from communicable diseases, says WHO. "I'm fearful of the resources ever being available to address it," rues Sadikot.

It is because India is so youthful—half the population is under 25—that the future of lifestyle diseases appears so chilling. At age 36, Ajay Kashyap was leading a normal life. He had a relatively tension-free transport business in

Chandigarh. He had no history of high blood pressure, cholesterol or heart ailments. Although he tipped the scales at 73 kg—too much for a 5 ft 4 inch frame—he hardly gave a thought to his diet, rich in red meat and cooked in desi ghee. But one night in 2000, he woke up with shortness of breath and acute pain in the left arm. A massive heart attack, sorted out with a triple coronary bypass. "The traditional Indian diet can itself be generous with calories," says Sadikot. "But urban residents are switching from ragi and fresh vegetables to fried and fast foods: a toxic brew for the Big Five."

Indians are believed to have genetic susceptibility to obesity, diabetes and the rest. "Possibly the by-product of ancestral genes evolved over centuries to hoard fat during cycles of feast and famine," says Mohan, who heads the Diabetes Specialities Centre in Chennai. "Genes play a protective role in white Caucasians," he points out. "Not so in India. If both your parents have diabetes, you have a 100 per cent risk of getting it. In the US, it is 50 per cent and in Europe, 33 per cent."

What explains the rising burden of cancer and respiratory problems? Lung cancer is most common among Indian men, with 33,000 new cases reported every year. In a comparative city survey on 2,000 people by the Pollution Board in 2004, Kolkata (closely followed by Delhi) was found to have the highest number of people suffering from lung cancer in the world. The study found, lung functions of 56 per cent in Kolkata, and 46 per cent in Delhi were impaired. Medics blame it on the huge increase in vehicular pollution. The other villain is, of course, tobacco. India has a total of 240 million smokers. No wonder, the country tops in oral cancer. Two out of five cancer cases in India are caused by tobacco. Anbumani Ramadoss, the Union health minister and one of India's strident 'no-tobacco' campaigners, claims

You need to strike the right work-life balance, or end up in a hospital.

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